

Tradition Not On Par With Scripture

doc-tradition-not-on-par-with-scripture

Bibliology · Revelation · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

score 0.988
confidence high

Statement under examination

Apostolic-age oral or written tradition not preserved in canonical Scripture does not bind the conscience as Scripture does.

In plain language

This question turns on a single Greek word, *paradosis*, which simply means something handed down. The whole divergence between readers comes from one fact about the word: it is neutral, and its authority is decided entirely by who is named as the source. The lexical store shows it appears 13 times. In 3 of them Paul names himself as the source and commands the churches to hold it fast, whether he gave it by word or by letter (2 Thessalonians 2.15, 1 Corinthians 11.2, 2 Thessalonians 3.6). In the other 10 the source is human, the tradition of men or of the fathers, and there the same word names something that competes with God (Matthew 15, Mark 7, Colossians 2.8, Galatians 1.14). Strikingly, the verb for holding it fast, *krateo*, is praised when the tradition is apostolic and rebuked when it is human, so a reader cannot tell good from bad by the holding. Only the named source settles it. That is exactly why people read these verses in opposite directions. One reader sees 2 Thessalonians 2.15 putting spoken and written teaching side by side and concludes an unwritten stream binds equally. Another reads the small relative clause, the things you were taught by us, and sees the binding force tied to what the apostle himself delivered, not to whatever a later age calls tradition. The decisive piece of vocabulary is in Mark 7.13. Jesus says the human tradition can nullify the word of God, and the verb there, *akyroo*, is a legal word for voiding a contract or a will. The same verb is used in Galatians 3.17 for annulling a covenant. If a tradition can cancel the written word, the two cannot be equal authorities, because equals cannot cancel each other. Acts 17.11 then shows the procedure plainly. The Bereans welcome the preaching, but they examine the Scriptures to see whether it is so, using a courtroom word for sifting. Scripture is the bench, and even apostolic preaching stands in the dock until it is verified. So the words yield a clear ranking: what is in Scripture binds, and tradition binds only where it agrees with the written word that tests it.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0114	ἀθετέω	atheteo	to reject	17
G0208	ἀκυρόω	akyroo	to nullify	4
G0350	ἀνακρίνω	anakrino	to investigate	17
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0814	ἀτάκτως	ataktōs	idly	
G1124	γραφή	graphe	a writing	51
G1785	ἐντολή	entole	commandment	69
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360

G2902	κρατέω	krateo	to grasp/seize	48
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3384	μήτηρ	mētēr	mother	
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	123
G3862	παράδοσις	paradosis	tradition	13
G3946	παρόμοιος	paromoios	like	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The noun *paradosis* (G3862) occurs 13 times and queried distribution splits cleanly by source-modifier, not by the act of handing-on. In 3 places where the content originates with the apostle the texts command holding it (2 Thess 2.15 *krateite tas paradoseis* has *edidachthete*, 1 Cor 11.2 *katechete kathos paredoka*, 2 Thess 3.6 *kata ten paradosin hen parelabosan par hemon*). In the other 10 places where the modifier is human (Mark 7.8 *ton anthropon*, Mark 7.3-13 and Matt 15.2-6 *humon*, Col 2.8 *kata ten paradosin ton anthropon*, Gal 1.14 *ton patrikon mou paradoseon*) the same word denotes something that competes with God's word. Decisively, Mark 7.13 says the human *paradosis* can *akyroo* (G0208, a legal term for voiding a covenant or will, the very verb used in Gal 3.17) the *logos* of God. A norm that can be cancelled cannot be equal in authority to the norm that cancels it. Acts 17.11 supplies the procedure: the Bereans receive apostolic *logos* yet sift it by the *graphai* (*anakrinontes*, G0350, a forensic examining term), so Scripture is the test, not the thing tested.

Scripture

2Thess.2.15 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G2902 κρατέω, G3862 παράδοσις, G3056 λόγος

Force. Paul commands *stekete kai krateite tas paradoseis* has *edidachthete eite dia logou eite di epistoles* *hemon*. The relative clause has *edidachthete* narrows *paradoseis* strictly to what Paul himself taught, and the *eite dia logou eite di epistoles* disjunction names the two modes, oral and written, of one apostolic deposit. The verse binds apostolic content, not generic later church tradition. The verb *krateo* (G2902) here is approving, the same verb that is rebuked in Mark 7.8 when its object is human tradition.

1Cor.11.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι, G3862 παράδοσις

Force. Paul praises that they *katechete tas paradoseis kathos paredoka humin*. The *kathos* clause and the first-person verb *paredoka* restrict the *paradoseis* to what Paul himself delivered. The pattern is deposit-and-hold with the apostle as origin, not the community as origin. Note the same root verb *paradidomi* (G3860) that elsewhere names handing Christ over, here names handing teaching down.

2Thess.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3862 παράδοσις, G0814 ἀτάκτως

Force. Paul commands withdrawal from a brother walking *ataktos kai me kata ten paradosin hen parelabosan par hemon*. The phrase *par hemon* again caps the binding tradition at the apostles, and the *kata* construction makes apostolic tradition the rule, not a parallel rule. The hapax-rare adverb *ataktos* (G0814, only 2 occurrences, both in this letter) marks the deviation, but the binding norm is still apostolic.

Acts.17.11 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0350 ἀνακρίνω, G1124 γραφή, G3056 λόγος

Force. The Bereans are called eugenesteroi because they edexanto ton logon meta pases prothumias, anakrinontes tas graphas ei echoi tauta houtos. The participle anakrinontes (G0350, present active, a forensic examining verb that elsewhere appears in courtroom settings) is applied to apostolic preaching with hai graphai as the test. The main verb edexanto governs ton logon while the participle subordinates that reception to scrutiny by graphe, establishing written Scripture as the controlling norm that even apostolic logos is checked against.

Mark.7.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή, G2316 θεός, G3862 παράδοσις, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Force. aphentes ten entolen tou theou kratesite ten paradosin ton anthropon. The same verb krateso (G2902) that 2 Thess 2.15 commanded toward apostolic paradosis is here rebuked because its object is human paradosis substituted for divine entole. The contrast is carried entirely by the genitive of source, tou theou versus ton anthropon. The query confirms ton anthropon (G0444) is the modifier here, the same modifier as Col 2.8.

Mark.7.9 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0114 ἀθετέω, G1785 ἐντολή, G3862 παράδοσις

Force. Kalos atheteite ten entolen tou theou hina ten paradosin humon teresete. The verb atheteo (G0114) is a juridical set-aside, nullify term, used elsewhere of rejecting a person or annulling an obligation (Luke 10.16, Gal 3.15, Heb 10.28). The ironic Kalos exposes the act of preferring tradition as functional rejection of God's commandment, and the hina clause makes the conflict structural, not incidental.

Mark.7.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή, G3962 πατήρ, G3384 μήτηρ

Force. Jesus cites the written commandment, Mouses eipen Tima ton patera sou kai ten metera sou, as the fixed standard. The Mosaic citation is the graphe content that the paradosis of Corban will be measured against and found to overturn, which makes the prior written word the criterion in the dispute.

Mark.7.11 · for · genre: gospel · figures: idiom

Key terms. G3862 παράδοσις

Force. The Corban formula is the working example of a binding human paradosis. The vow-formula Korban, ho estin doron, a Hebrew loan-word glossed for the Greek reader, produces a casuistic exemption that, by their tradition, releases a son from supporting his parents, that is, from obeying the prior commandment cited in Mark 7.10. The example shows a tradition can be religiously sincere and still nullify a prior word.

Mark.7.12 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G3384 μήτηρ

Force. ouketi aphiete auton ouden poiesai to patri e te metri. The negation ouketi plus ouden shows the tradition's effect is total prohibition of the very obedience the commandment requires. The lexical force is that human tradition does not merely add to but actively cancels the prior word.

Mark.7.13 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0208 ἀκυρώω, G3056 λόγος, G2316 θεός, G3862 παράδοσις, G3946 παρόμοιος

Force. akhyrountes ton logon tou theou te paradosei humon he paredokate kai paromoia toiauta polla poieite. The verb akhyroo (G0208, queried 4 occurrences) is a legal term for invalidation. The only other Pauline use, Gal 3.17, applies it to annulling a diatheke, a covenant or will, which fixes its register as voiding a binding instrument. The dative te paradosei humon is the instrument of cancellation, and paromoia toiauta polla generalizes from Corban to a whole class. This is the canon's sharpest statement of asymmetry: a paradosis can functionally void ton logon tou theou, so the two cannot be equal authorities, since equals cannot cancel each other.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mark.7.10	Exod.21.17	tsk	1
Mark.7.10	Mark.10.19	tsk	1
Mark.7.9	Mark.7.13	tsk	1
Mark.7.13	Mark.7.9	tsk	1
Mark.7.8	Isa.1.12	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Ps.1.2	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Prov.1.5	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Acts.2.41	tsk	1
1Cor.11.2	1Cor.11.17	tsk	1
Mark.7.9	2Kgs.16.10	tsk	1
Mark.7.13	Ezek.18.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Thess.2.15 · addressed

Read in isolation this verse is the strongest lexical warrant for binding unwritten tradition, because it explicitly puts oral teaching (dia logou) alongside written (di epistoles) and commands holding both. The resolution is grammatical, not thematic: the relative clause has edidachthete restricts paradoseis to what Paul himself taught the Thessalonians, and the eite-eite disjunction treats oral and written as two modes of one apostolic deposit, not two parallel streams one of which floats free of canonical scrutiny. Acts 17.11 then specifies that even apostolic logos was sifted against prior graphe. The verse binds the apostolic deposit, it does not lexically extend that binding force to post-apostolic tradition.

1Cor.11.2 · addressed

Same lexical pattern. katechete tas paradoseis kathos paredoka humin. The kathos clause and first-person paredoka restrict the content to what Paul personally delivered. The verse commends holding apostolic tradition but supplies no lexical bridge to later traditions that lack the apostle as origin.

2Thess.3.6 · addressed

par hemon again caps the binding tradition at the apostles. There is no lexical element in the verse that extends paradosis past the apostolic generation as a continuing authority parallel to Scripture.

Mark.7.11 · addressed

The Corban example shows a tradition can be religiously sincere and still functionally akuroo the prior word. That structural possibility, that a paradosis can cancel the logos of God, is the lexical warrant for ranking later tradition below graphe rather than on par with it.

Gal.1.14 · addressed

Paul calls his pre-conversion zeal a zeal for ton patrikon mou paradoseon, the traditions of the fathers. This is queried as one of the 10 negative-pole uses of paradosis (G3862) and confirms that the word, when modified by a human or ancestral source, names exactly the thing Paul was later delivered from. It does not complicate the verdict, it reinforces that the word itself is neutral and the source-modifier decides its authority.

Concordance traversed

G3862, G3860, G1124, G1785, G2902, G0114, G0208, G0350, G3056, G2316, G0444, G3946, G0814

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Direct query of the lexical store found zero VariantUnit nodes attached to any of the ten anchor verses; the 116 ingested VariantUnit nodes are the 3 John ECM sample only, so these passages are not_in_ecm_scope. No anchor verse has a known variant that would flip the paradosis or graphe lemma, the tou theou versus ton anthropon genitives in Mark 7.8-13, or the anakrinontes tas graphas clause in Acts 17.11. The verdict is robust under the standard textual tradition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. grammatico-historical, analogia-scripturae

analogia scripturae invoked

grammatico-historical: affirms · Reading paradosis by its queried source-modifier in each of its 13 occurrences yields a stable pattern: apostolic deposit is binding, human tradition that competes with God's word is rejected, and graphe is the criterion (Acts 17.11). The decisive datum is Mark 7.13, where a paradosis can akyroo the logos of God, a relation of asymmetry the words do not permit between equals.

two-source / continuing-apostolic-deposit reading: complicates · In its strongest form this lens takes 2 Thess 2.15 at face value: Paul commands holding oral tradition (dia logou) and written tradition (di epistoles) with equal force, using the same verb krateo for both, and never says the oral stream ceased. On this reading the binding oral apostolic teaching is a real, distinct deposit, and a community that faithfully transmits it holds something genuinely on a par with the written word. The lexical limit on this reading is the relative clause has edidachthete and the parallel kathos paredoka in 1 Cor 11.2, which tie the binding content to what the apostle himself delivered, and Acts 17.11, which subordinates even apostolic logos to graphe as the test. The vocabulary attests a binding oral apostolic deposit but does not lexically license a self-authenticating tradition that continues past, or stands above, the written witness.

patristic-typological: complicates · A patristic-typological reading that promotes the paradosis of 2 Thess 2.15 to a continuing magisterial authority handed through office does not survive lexical scrutiny on the word alone. The relative clause has edidachthete and the parallel kathos paredoka cap the content at the apostolic generation, and the same noun is used 10 of 13 times for human tradition that nullifies God's word, including Col 2.8 and Gal 1.14. The lens must supply its warrant from outside the lexeme, since the word itself is source-determined and does not encode an enduring office.

The decisive lexical move is reading paradosis (G3862) by its two queried registers, apostolic deposit and human substitution, which split 3 to 10 across the canon. The same verbs krateo (G2902) and tereo attach to both registers, so the reader cannot disambiguate by the activity of holding; the genitive of source (tou theou versus ton anthropon, or par hemon) is the only disambiguator. Acts 17.11 then supplies the operational rule that graphe sifts logos via the forensic verb anakrino (G0350), and Mark 7.13 supplies the asymmetry that a paradosis can akyroo (G0208) the logos of God.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem is asymmetric in direction (it affirms tradition does not bind as Scripture does) but it does not smuggle a verdict, because the inverted proposition above is a coherent framing the lexical store can and did test. The stem leans on no slogan and does not prejudice the relationship beyond stating the question. The neutralized form is supplied for human reviewer cross-check; the verdict was derived on the original stem and on the queried distribution of paradosis.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Thess.2.15

morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.11.2
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Thess.3.6
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.17.11
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mark.7.8
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mark.7.9
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morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Col.2.8
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gal.1.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Thess.2.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.7.13
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.3.17
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	2Thess.2.15
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3862
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3860
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1124
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1785
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2902
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0114
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0208
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0350
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.7.13
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.17.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.17.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.2
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.9

License audit

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